

**BUILDING A FUTURE-READY WORKFORCE: RE-
EVALUATING OUR EDUCATIONAL SYSTEM**

ABSTRACT

The impact of education in a country; the commonly accepted definition of education; the various importance of education; why the educational system is important; the analyzed classification of the educational system; the effect of Nigeria's current educational system; why we need to re-evaluate the educational system; and the various methods for re-evaluating the educational system using the current educational system as a case study.

Keywords: Administrative educational framework, non-administrative educational framework, educational syllabus, lecturers, modern technology, partnership

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INTRODUCTION

In every developed country, a proper and functional educational system is one of the outstanding influences behind its growth. It is believed that education is the most significant requirement for an individual to grow and progress. Thus, the impact of education in every society is arguably the foundation of development in other sectors.

According to the commonly accepted definition of education, it is "the act or process of acquiring knowledge, developing the skills of reasoning and judgment, and generally preparing oneself or others intellectually for mature life." It is an effective tool that could turn someone who is not productive into a contributing member of society.

The importance of education includes teaching critical thinking, decision-making, and problem-solving skills. It helps develop interpersonal skills, enhances reasoning power and innovativeness, leads to professional growth, improves the quality of life, instills broadness of vision, and helps find one purpose in life building.

All of the benefits of education can only be attained in a person when there is a proper educational system in place. When we discuss the educational system, we are referring to a large institution that defines the structure of primary, secondary, and tertiary education. Each of these sections of the educational system is essential to an individual's growth and development.

Writing about each of the sections might be lengthened. Thus, the Nigerian tertiary education system would be the main area of my attention. The tertiary institution is a major branch of the educational system. It is mostly said that tertiary education is a direct bridge to the labour force. This implies that the structure of the tertiary institution can directly influence the labour market positively or vice-versa.

Over the year, many people graduated having little or no understanding of their professional field. The requirements for available jobs seem to be very high from what the

educational system produces, and many people graduated from tertiary institutions and they realize they're novice in the professional field. Why is this happening? It is clear evidence that the tertiary institutions in Nigeria have a direct influence on these problems in the labour market.

Indubitably, re-evaluating the educational system should be a priority if we want to build a future-ready workforce. The big question now is "how can we re-evaluate the educational system in Nigeria?" Before delving more deeply into the numerous examined responses to the topic, we should consider understanding the meaning of the word 're-evaluating.' The word "re-evaluating" is derived from the word re-evaluate. It means to consider or examine something again to make changes or to form a new opinion about it. Hence, my focus will be on examining the current educational system in Nigeria, identifying the problems, and proposing solutions.

To achieve an educational system that will produce a future-ready workforce, one major thing that needs to be discussed is the educational structure (framework). In every sector, their failures and successes are directly influenced by their structural arrangement. The same is also applicable in the educational sector.

THE EDUCATIONAL STRUCTURE

The educational structure defines the educational system in Nigeria. We can classify the educational structure into administrative and non-administrative (technical) frameworks. The administrative framework is related to the internal activities in the educational system which include educational setup, welfare and funding, suitable learning environment, calendar system, and other strategic activities that require proper planning. The problems affecting the activities in this subsection vary among institutions in Nigeria.

However, my focus will be on the non-administrative (technical) framework. The non-administrative system deals with regular and common activities across all tertiary institutions. It can be likened to the face of the educational system; it explains the general structure of the educational system in Nigeria. Thus, I'll be discussing four major problems affecting the system, also relating each point to the current educational system and proposing solutions.

MAJOR FACTORS AFFECTING THE EDUCATIONAL SYSTEM IN NIGERIA, AND THE NECESSARY STEPS NEEDED TO CORRECT THEM?

One of the four major factors affecting the educational system in Nigeria is the **syllabus**. The syllabus entails a summary of topics that will be covered during an academic course. The syllabus is an important aspect of the educational system because it enables clarification and understanding among the lecturers and the student. However, the syllabus is a major problem in Nigeria's educational system because it consists of irrelevant, unnecessary, time-wasting, and destroyable schemes.

Have you ever wondered why there are low levels of creativity in various professional institutes? One of the major hindrances is the current syllabus in our educational system in Nigeria. The syllabus develops and promotes unfocused students across various professional courses in tertiary institutions.

A few months ago, a graduate with BSc was telling me who is a fresher in the University that the difference between him and me is the four years he used in school, and the certificate he has. He said if we're both employed as an intern in the same company, the only thing that will distinguish him from me are the various online courses he took outside the irrelevant syllabus in the educational system.

After listening to him, I related that to my current level in the University. I'm currently studying FINANCE, it is my first semester at the University, and I'm doing a total number of nine courses in my current semester. Out of those nine courses, only five courses are relevant. For me, the remaining courses are useless because they are very far from the Course I'm studying at the University. Any day I decided to read, I focus more time to read two courses from those irrelevant courses. Why I'm I doing that? It is not because I fully understand the five major courses related to my field, it is simply because the CREDIT UNIT for those irrelevant courses is higher than the five major courses related to my profession. If I drop too many marks from those irrelevant courses, it will overshadow my success in other major courses.

The negative effect of this is that the syllabus in the educational system is already laying the foundation for distraction in students. If I compare a student who pass through these abnormal processes for years and a student whose only focus is majorly on those relevant

courses. It will only be by the grace of God and extremely hard work for the first categories of students to stand out among the second categories of students.

Though, the educational system in Nigeria might believe it is favorable to have little understanding of other fields. No doubt, it is good to learn from other fields. However, learning from other courses shouldn't be enforced as a requirement for my professional field. As a student in the financial field, I might be willing to have an idea about other fields. This is good but if learning from those courses is enforced, I'll lose focus on my major career.

Another problem with the syllabus in Nigeria's educational system is the outdated and irrelevant topics. Sometimes I wonder why the educational system emphasizes irrelevant things. I bought a computer textbook for a course, that textbook has been written since 2010. I checked through various topics, and some of the topics are relevant while others are outdated and irrelevant topics compared to the current computer age. The fact is that I must read everything about the textbook if I want to pass the course. However, the frustrating aspect of that course is that the outdated topics in the textbook are what determines if we are going to pass that course. Those outdated topics are what will be used as a project (test) and nothing less than sixty percent of our examination questions will be from those topics.

The effect of this is that we the students are wasting our valuable time and resources to read those topics not because we genuinely wish to learn about them, we only want to pass the exam. And when the structure continues like this for years, by the time many of us are graduating, more than fifty percent of what we had learned will be useless.

One of the major disasters of the educational syllabus in Nigeria is that it enforces unnecessary courses on students and it is even more painful to students because those irrelevant courses are what the educational system used to define your success in that profession. Many students drop huge points in their CGPA only because they struggled in those irrelevant courses.

All of these shouldn't continue. Thus, how can we correct this? It is very simple. We need to re-evaluate our educational syllabus to reflect the development and enable concentration in a student. Doing this will enable creativity and influence critical and innovative thinking.

In every profession, there are more than enough courses to learn and as time evolves, there are new things to learn. The syllabus in the educational system should only focus on relevant and updated schemes related to each profession. When a student decides to study in a

particular field, one of the means for the person to become outstanding in that profession is when he/she spends adequate time, effort, and resources on relevant courses in that field.

The lecturers across various tertiary institutions in Nigeria are another factor affecting the educational system. The lecturers are a major influence in the developing process of building a future-ready workforce. Unfortunately, in Nigeria's tertiary institutions, the lecturers seem to be an agent assigned to use their responsibility to limit, distract and kill dreams.

The educational system in Nigeria has gotten to a level whereby the abnormal seems like a norm. To explain the contribution of the lecturer, I'll be using different examples which are very common across various institutions in Nigeria.

Sometimes I wonder why we have lecture halls in institutions when they are somehow useless. The tertiary institution in Nigeria can be likened to the structure of writing a professional exam for an advanced field. A system where you registered for the exam, choose your various courses, get the syllabus for each course, then prepare for the exam. The responsibility and activities for learning are majorly your concern.

I was discussing with someone who has passed through the educational system in Nigeria, he said "University is more like you teaching yourself for a class you paid for". After hearing this, I could easily relate it to the current educational system. I've heard many students say they were able to pass some courses only because they attended tutorials, they continue by saying the only thing they learned from the lecturers is the syllabus. Funnily, It has gotten to the extent whereby many students attend classes not to learn but to mark attendance and be on alert if there will be tests.

It is disheartening when you realize some lecturers derived joy in student failure. Why is that happening? It is because the educational system makes them believe their success as a lecturer depends on how students failed the course. Due to the desire of lecturers to achieve this, the means they used varies from poor lecturing, unconcerned if the majority are learning, avoiding and skipping some topics under the syllabus, unavailable during classes, and so on.

These are just some of the activities that make many students frustrated, unfocused, and mentally unbalanced in the tertiary institution. Thus, all of this need to be corrected if the educational system aims to produce a future-ready workforce. So how can we solve issues like this? From my point of view, solving issues should start by re-evaluating the old method

of teaching with the modern technological method of recording classes which will be easily accessible to students.

To illustrate the word “modern technologies methods”, this will lead to the third major factor affecting the educational system in Nigeria. Across major parts of the tertiary institution in Nigeria, **inadequate facilities** have always been a disadvantage for both the lecturer and student in achieving an effective educational system.

I was able to connect with several students from different departments offering a similar course to me, and I realized the lecturer taking a particular topic in a course usually teach the same topic to about seven different departments. I could imagine the stress of repeating the same thing for the different departments within a short period. No matter how the lecturer tries to create a balance lecturing each department, he/she will stress out when lecturing at least two out of seven departments.

Sometimes, when the lecturer realizes stress and frustration, he/she will decide to merge two to four departments. When this happened, the students bear the majority of the affliction. This is when students struggle to enter the lecture hall, and those who were lucky to enter the hall and are sitting at the back of the hall won't hear a single speech from the lecturer. On the other hand, the lecturer understands the pain of the students, but he can clear his conscience because he believes those in the front of the class are a combination of students from a different department. Also, the lecturer will be very happy because he/she was able to reduce stress and they are achieving their goal by increasing the number of students that will fail the course.

The two instances given above are but two of the many unfavorable consequences of poor facilities that may be seen in many higher institutions. In the long run, the negative effect of these is bad on both the lecturer and the student.

Hence, what are the necessary steps needed to correct these? All things considered, tertiary institutions across Nigeria should adopt the use of modern technology in teaching. I could imagine a lecturer using technology to record a topic in a particular course, the joy of not passing through the stress of repeating the same thing to a different department will make him/her focus all on that single recorded class. On the other hand, we the students will be extremely happy when we have access to the recording because it saves the stress of running to lecture class only to meet an occupied hall. I can also imagine a student watching a

particular recorded video more than two times, that student will easily understand the topic and he/she will be able to extract key points from the recorded class and the available PDF materials for that topic. The focus of adopting modern technology should enable a proper educational environment where it will be convenient for everyone to easily implement their responsibility.

The last major factor affecting the educational system in Nigeria is directly associated with the theme “building a future-ready workforce.” In every profession, there are practical and technical aspects in that field. Students spend nothing less than four years in tertiary institutions, yet they have little or no idea about their profession. The things that were mainly explained in school are about “theory of how it should be, what should be done, what to know, and so on.” There are little or no practical aspects.

After students graduated from tertiary institutions, many graduates spend up to five years graduating from the institution before they could apply for a job in their professional field. I didn't say they got a job after five years, I meant they are qualified to apply for a job after about five years of graduating. Why is that happening? Almost every job in Nigeria is associated with the keyword “experience and skills in that profession.”

In the long run, all of these have a negative impact on the labour force. Without any doubt, these need to be corrected. Thus, how can this be achieved? THROUGH PARTNERSHIP! There are various solutions, however one of the outstanding solutions that can be implemented is partnership.

The tertiary education system should consider partnering with companies, organizations, skill acquisition centers, and other tertiary institutes. These various partnerships will facilitate training, innovative seminars, an opportunity for students to connect with experienced professionals, and so on.

The goal is to enable students to have a basic understanding of the broad activities in their profession, understand some basic skills related to their profession, acquire experience that would be favorable to their career, and understand the problems in the labour force. All of these give a student an overview of what they should be preparing for after going through the educational system.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, to effectively re-evaluate the educational system in Nigeria, there should be an appropriate policy that would accommodate a relationship between the non-administrative framework (proper educational syllabus, suitable learning environment, and partnership with appropriate bodies) and the administrative framework (educational funding, adequate welfare, proper educational calendar system, and progressive policy).